Red Rain: A Sky Mystery With a Surprising Answer

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For thousands of years, people have seen rain that falls red. They called it 'blood rain.' In 1841, strange matter fell on a field in Tennessee, and a scientist guessed wind had carried it there. A **waterspout** is a spinning column of air over water. It can pull up water and whatever is in it, carry it for miles, and drop it somewhere else. What turns rain red? In 2001, red rain fell during the **monsoon** in Kerala, India. A scientist named Godfrey Louis said the red cells were alien **microbes** from a comet. A government study disagreed. The cells were **spores** of Trentepohlia, a reddish-orange **alga** that grows on trees, rocks, and even lamp posts. The **spores** most likely came from nearby, swept into rain clouds by the wind. Other blood rains have been traced to red dust blown from the **Sahara** desert. So the sky's strangest rain usually has an earthly source after all.

Word Treasure

waterspout -- A waterspout is a spinning column of air over water.

monsoon -- A monsoon is a season of heavy rain in a warm place.

spores -- Spores are tiny cells that some plants and fungi use to make new plants.

alga -- An alga is a simple plant that often grows in water or on damp surfaces.

microbes -- Microbes are tiny living things too small to see without a microscope.

Sahara -- The Sahara is a huge desert in Africa.

Background you need

For thousands of years, people have seen rain that falls red and called it 'blood rain.'

Wind and water can carry tiny things, like dust or spores, for miles and drop them somewhere else.

Scientists study strange rain to find out what really caused it, instead of guessing.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists, including Godfrey Louis, who studied red rain in Kerala, India.
WHAT: Strange red rain has been traced to things like red dust from the Sahara and spores of a reddish-orange alga, not to blood or aliens.
WHERE: In many places, including Tennessee, Kerala in India, and the Sahara desert.
WHY: Because wind and waterspouts can carry dust and spores for miles and drop them into rain clouds.

Why it matters

When something strange happens in the sky, asking questions and checking the facts helps you tell a real mystery from a simple explanation.

Test what you remember

1. What have people called rain that falls red?

(A) 'Fire rain'
(B) 'Ghost rain'
(C) 'Stone rain'
(D) 'Blood rain'

2. What is a waterspout?

(A) A river that flows uphill
(B) A big wave in the ocean
(C) A kind of rain cloud
(D) A spinning column of air over water

3. What did Godfrey Louis say the red cells were?

(A) Red paint from a factory
(B) Alien microbes from a comet
(C) Spores of a reddish-orange alga
(D) Dust from the Sahara

4. What did the government study say the cells really were?

(A) Blood from animals
(B) Alien microbes from a comet
(C) Spores of Trentepohlia, a reddish-orange alga
(D) Sand from the beach

5. Where does Trentepohlia grow?

(A) Only in the ocean
(B) In volcanoes
(C) Only on Mars
(D) On trees, rocks, and even lamp posts

6. What have other blood rains been traced to?

(A) Red dust blown from the Sahara desert
(B) Pollution from cars
(C) Rain from outer space
(D) Leaves from trees

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Godfrey Louis: Said the red cells were alien microbes from a comet.**

2. **A government study: Said the cells were spores of Trentepohlia, a reddish-orange alga.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):